

The Long Way Back

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*a field guide for coming home
to your body after harm*



INNER HOUR

The Long Way Back.

First edition.

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This book is a companion, not a treatment. It is not a substitute for trauma-informed care, medical attention, or crisis services.

If you are in immediate danger, call your local emergency number. In the United States, you can also reach a trained counselor at 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline) or text HOME to 741741. The National Domestic Violence Hotline is available 24/7 at 1-800-799-7233 or text START to 88788.

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a letter, in two parts.

For the person who got out, and finds the hard part is now.

Nobody told you that surviving was the easy part. You probably wouldn't have believed them if they had. While it was happening, you were a body working — calculating, reading the room, holding the air still. There was no time to feel any of it. There still isn't, some days.

But you are here now, on the other side of something. The other side is supposed to be the relief. What nobody told you is that the body does not know the war is over. It keeps showing up to a fight that already happened.

This book is for that body.

This is not a curriculum. It is a toolkit. There is no order. There is no progress bar. You will not graduate from any of this.

Some pages will be useful today. Some will be useful in a year. Some will be useful never, and that is fine — they were not for you and that is information, too.

There is also no version of this that is fast. Coming back to yourself is slow work. The work is mostly noticing. Noticing is the work.

You do not have to forgive anyone. You do not have to make meaning of what happened. You do not have to be wiser, kinder, or softer for having lived through it. You only have to keep being here.

Welcome back. Take your shoes off. The room is yours.

how to use this.

This book is not for cover-to-cover reading. It is for opening when something is asking for attention.

There are nine sections. They are tools, not steps. Use the table of contents like a menu. Some days you need the flashback page. Some days you need the page that gives you permission to take a long bath. Some days you will need the page that reminds you that your body learned exactly what it was trained to learn.

Write in it. Don't write in it. Skip the prompts. Cross out the ones that don't fit. Add your own. The fact boxes are there when you want the science; skip them when you don't. This book exists in service of you. Not the other way around.

If a section asks you to feel something you cannot feel today, put the book down. The work is not the book. The work is the life you are rebuilding around it.

contents.

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I

What happened to your nervous system

your body learned the shape of harm exactly. that learning is what kept you here.



on staying on.

Your body adapted exactly the way bodies adapt. The reactions you have now belong to the environment that shaped them — and that environment is no longer here.

When you live for a long time with someone whose mood is the weather, your body becomes a barometer. You learn to read footsteps. You learn to map silences. You learn to know, two rooms away, whether tonight will be one of those nights.

That kind of attention is expensive. It uses the same circuitry as running from a predator, except the predator is in the kitchen, and you cannot run for years. So the system stays on, and the system learns that on is the default.

the chemistry of staying on.

Chronic threat changes the body's chemistry.

Cortisol is the body's primary stress hormone. In healthy stress, it spikes and then clears within an hour or two. In chronic threat — the kind a long relationship of harm produces — cortisol stays elevated for months or years. Researchers call this allostatic load: the wear-and-tear of a body that never gets the all-clear.

Elevated cortisol disrupts sleep architecture, suppresses immune function, raises blood pressure, and quietly shrinks the hippocampus — the brain region that timestamps memories. This is one reason your memory of those years can feel both unbearably vivid and strangely smudged at the same time.

You are not imagining the cost. It is measurable in your bloodwork. It is also reversible — slowly, with safety, sleep, and time.

on the job.

Hypervigilance is not a flaw. It is a job your body took on when nobody else would. It kept you alive. It is allowed to be tired now. It is allowed to be wrong about the door slamming. It is allowed to be wrong about the tone of a voice on the phone.

Being wrong about danger is the goal. It means your body is learning, in real time, that the danger is over. That learning is slow because the original learning was so total. Be patient with the body. It is trying to update its files.

what the body keeps remembering.

Sometimes the body speeds up. Sometimes it disappears.

There is a nerve — the longest in the body — that runs from the brainstem down through the chest and belly. It is the body's quiet translator between threat and ease. Researchers spent the last few decades mapping the way it shapes how we feel inside our own skin.

When the body feels safe enough, the shoulders drop, the face softens, the voice finds its range. You can hear nuance in someone else's. The room stops being a stage.

When the body senses a threat it can move against, the heart speeds up, the jaw sets, the breath goes shallow. Useful for a house fire. Exhausting for a Tuesday afternoon.

And when the body has been overwhelmed for too long — when fighting and leaving have both been taken off the table — it learns a third thing. It goes quiet. Numb, foggy, slow. The lights are on, the rooms are empty.

If you spent years in that quiet because there was no exit, the body can get stuck inside it. The work is not to vault back into ease. The work is to remember the path: small, repeated experiences of safety the body can actually feel.

on what it feels like.

What it feels like:

A heartbeat in the throat. Shoulders climbing toward the ears. A jaw that stays clenched even in sleep. Sleep that is more like monitoring than rest. The chest that flutters when a car pulls into the driveway. The flinch when a hand moves toward you, even a hand that loves you.

The freeze that comes out of nowhere in a grocery store aisle. The startle at a dropped fork. The way your stomach knows the sound of the front door before your mind does.

Naming the symptom is not a diagnosis. It is a way of saying: my body is doing something. The thing it is doing makes sense. I am not crazy. I am calibrated.

the long exhale.

Why the breath out is the medicine.

Your vagus nerve runs from your brainstem to your gut, and it is the body's main brake on the stress response. Long exhales activate it; short, sharp inhales suppress it.

When the exhale is longer than the inhale, heart rate slows, blood pressure drops, and the body receives the chemical signal: the threat has passed.

This is why every traditional calming practice — yogic breathing, monastic chant, lullabies, sighing — ends up in the same place. Make the out-breath longer than the in-breath. The body will believe you faster than your mind will.

a practice for the body.

Let your eyes land on something stable. Then another. Let the room announce itself slowly. The lamp. The window. The corner of the rug. The pen on the desk. The light moving across the curtain. There is no order. There is no quota. The point is to let the room be more real than the memory for a minute.

Then orient outward. Where are the doors. Where is the warm corner. Where is the cooler one. Your body needs to know it can move through this space if it wants to.

Now lengthen the breath out. Whatever the in-breath is, let the out-breath be longer. A long, audible sigh works. The exhale is what tells the system that the moment has passed.

If the long breath is too much, do one. A single audible sigh shifts the system. There is no minimum dose, and there is no correct number. The medicine is in the noticing.

my body learned to ___ in order to survive ____.

Finish the sentence as many times as you can. Be specific. The body remembers the specifics.

a small, true thing. _____

*Your body did its job.
It is allowed to learn a new one, slowly.*



II

The flashback protocol

a flashback is not a memory you choose to revisit. it is a memory that returns without asking.



on what it actually is.

A flashback is not a memory you choose to revisit. It is a memory that returns without asking. It does not feel like remembering. It feels like happening.

Flashbacks are not always pictures. They are more often a feeling — small, hard, sudden. A smell that takes you back. A tone of voice that drops you into a body that is twelve years old, or twenty-three, or any age except the one you are now.

When a flashback hits, the work is not to understand it. The work is to come back to today.

why a smell can do that.

Sensory memory has a back door.

Most memory is processed through the hippocampus and tagged with time. Sensory memory — especially smell — bypasses that step. Olfactory signals route directly to the amygdala, the brain's threat-tagging center, before the conscious mind ever weighs in.

This is why a perfume in a crowded room can drop you into a moment from twenty years ago, intact and uncatalogued. The smell didn't go through the calendar. It went straight to the alarm.

Knowing this does not stop the flashback. But it can stop the second wound — the one where you decide that your reaction means you are unstable, or weak, or making it up. You are not. You are wired exactly the way humans are wired.

the five steps, in order.

When a flashback hits.

One. Say out loud: I am having a flashback. Name it. The name is the first crack in the spell.

Two. Locate your body in this room. Press your feet into the floor. Put your hand flat on a surface. Cold water on the wrists.

Three. Tell yourself, out loud, three facts about today. The year. Your age. The room you are in. The people in your life who are alive and on your side.

Four. Move. Stand up. Walk to a different room. Pour a glass of water. The body needs to feel that it can leave a moment.

Five. After. Eat something. Wrap up. Lie down if you can. The flashback was work. The body is tired. Let it rest.

why the cold water helps.

The dive reflex is a built-in reset.

Mammals have a reflex called the mammalian dive response: when cold hits the face or wrists, heart rate slows, blood pressure drops, and the parasympathetic nervous system kicks in. It is the body's hardware reset.

Dialectical Behavior Therapy formalized this into a skill called TIPP — Temperature, Intense exercise, Paced breathing, Paired muscle relaxation. The temperature piece works in seconds.

Cold water on the wrists, an ice pack on the back of the neck, splashing the face, or holding a cold can to the cheekbones can interrupt a panic spiral faster than any cognitive technique. It is not a metaphor. It is biology.

my top triggers.

A trigger is not a weakness. It is a piece of unresolved information. Mapping your triggers does not eliminate them — it gives you a place to put them so they don't keep ambushing you.

THE TRIGGER	WHAT IT REMINDS THE BODY OF

on why this is not forever.

Reconsolidation: memories can change.

For a long time, the standard model said traumatic memory was permanent — etched, immutable, the same every time it was retrieved. We now know that's not how memory works.

Every time a memory is recalled, it enters a brief, malleable window — usually a few hours — during which it can be updated before being filed again. This is called reconsolidation.

Therapies like EMDR (Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing) and certain forms of trauma-focused CBT use this window deliberately, pairing the recall with a present-moment safe sensation so the body files the memory with new information attached: that was then. I am here. I survived.

You do not have to do this alone, and you do not have to do it now. But it is worth knowing: the memory's grip is not the final word.

when i'm flashing back i am ___ years old and ____.

Finish the sentence. The body has an answer even if the mind doesn't.

a small, true thing. _____

*The flashback ends. They always end.
You have survived every one of them,
including the ones you cannot remember surviving.*



III

Stabilization before story

the story can wait. the story is more patient than you have been told.



on the order of things.

There is a story to tell about what happened to you. You will, eventually, want to tell it. To a therapist. To a journal. To yourself.

You do not have to tell it yet.

Trauma work that starts with the story, before the body is steady enough to hold it, can re-injure. The order matters. Stabilization before story.

Always.

This is not a stalling tactic. This is the actual protocol that every reputable trauma model — Judith Herman's three-stage framework, somatic experiencing, internal family systems — agrees on. Safety first. Then story. Then reconnection.

what it looks like.

What stabilization looks like, in plain words:

Sleep, in the rough neighborhood of regular. Food, more or less on purpose. Movement, of any kind, on most days. One or two humans you can reach. A roof that will be over your head for at least the next month. The basic noisy yes of a body that knows it is going to make it through the week.

If those are not in place yet, this is the work. Not the story. The story can wait. The story is more patient than you have been told.

sleep, after.

Why sleep is the first piece of medicine.

Sleep is when the brain consolidates memory, clears metabolic waste from neural tissue, and regulates the HPA axis — the hormonal system that runs the stress response. A body without sleep cannot heal from chronic stress, no matter how much therapy it gets.

Trauma disrupts sleep in specific ways: harder to fall asleep (the body resists losing vigilance), early-morning waking (cortisol surges around 3–5 a.m.), fragmented REM (the stage where emotional memory is processed).

The first move is not eight perfect hours. The first move is a consistent wake time, light in the eyes within an hour of waking, no screens for the last forty-five minutes before bed, and a cool, dark room. These sound small. They are the foundation.

If sleep is genuinely broken — months of under four or five hours — talk to a doctor. Trauma-informed sleep specialists exist. CBT-I (cognitive behavioral therapy for insomnia) is one of the most effective non-pharmaceutical treatments for any condition, full stop.

food, after.

What the body needs when it has been at war.

Chronic stress depletes specific nutrients: magnesium (used up by cortisol), B vitamins (used up by stress metabolism), vitamin D (often low in people who have stopped going outside), omega-3s (anti-inflammatory; usually depleted).

Protein at breakfast — even small — stabilizes blood sugar across the morning and reduces afternoon anxiety. Skipping breakfast keeps cortisol elevated; the body interprets a missed meal as another stressor.

Gut and brain are wired together by the vagus nerve. An estimated 90 percent of serotonin is produced in the gut. Fermented foods (yogurt, kefir, sauerkraut, kimchi), fiber, and reducing ultra-processed foods all measurably lower depression and anxiety scores in controlled studies.

This is not a diet. This is fuel for a system that has been running on stress hormones. Start with one warm meal a day, eaten sitting down. That is the whole intervention.

the range where you can still hear yourself. _____

There is a range where the body can feel things and still keep functioning — where feeling and functioning overlap. Not calm. Not numb. Just present enough to stay in the room.

Above that range: too much. Heart pounding, skin hot, thoughts moving faster than you can catch them. The urge to run or fight or break something. The body has tipped into too much aliveness to hold.

Below that range: too little. Numb, foggy, can't get out of bed, can't remember the last meal. Voice flat. Time loses shape. The body has gone behind a door it built for itself.

The goal is not to live in the middle forever. The goal is to notice when you have left it, and to have one small return-tool ready. When the body is too lit up: cold, slow breath, a weighted blanket. When the body has gone quiet: warmth, slow movement, sunlight, a phone call to someone whose voice has texture.

resourcing.

Resourcing is the practice of building a felt sense of safety in the body, on purpose, when nothing is wrong.

Think of a place — real or imagined — where you have felt safe. A grandmother's kitchen. A specific beach. A bookshop you wandered alone. A friend's living room. The character of a felt place, not the postcard.

Bring it into the body. What did the air smell like. What did the light look like. What did your shoulders do when you walked in.

Sit with the body's yes for sixty seconds. That is the work. The body is laying down a path it can find again. Neurons that fire together wire together — and that includes the safe ones, not just the alarm ones.

a place i have been safe.

Describe it. The light. The sound. What your shoulders did when you walked in.

my daily stabilizers.

Sleep. Food. Movement. Contact. Light.

What is in place. What is not yet. Underline one to work on this week.
One.

- ☐ A consistent wake time, seven days a week (within an hour either way)
- ☐ Light in the eyes within an hour of waking — outside if possible, near a window if not
- ☐ Protein at breakfast, even small (eggs, yogurt, leftover anything)
- ☐ One warm meal eaten sitting down, no screen
- ☐ Movement of any kind, most days — walking counts, stretching counts, dancing in the kitchen counts
- ☐ One human contact: a text, a call, a face you see in person
- ☐ Forty-five minutes without screens before bed
- ☐ Room cool enough to sleep in (around 65°F is the research sweet spot)
- ☐ A bedtime that does not change by more than an hour, weekends included

IV

Rebuilding identity

you are not going back. you are going forward to someone who has carried this.



three versions of you.

Who were you before. Who were you forced to be. Who are you now.

Living inside harm rewrites you. Your tastes shrink to what is tolerable. Your opinions become careful. Your jokes get smaller. Your laugh learns to read the room before it lands. You become a person who can survive being around them.

That person is not the whole of you. That person is the version that made it out. They deserve thanks, not a permanent contract.

whose voice.

There is a voice in your head that is not yours. Probably more than one. The voice of the person who told you what you were like. The voice of the family that decided what kind of girl, boy, person, kid you were. The voice of the partner who narrated you back to yourself, daily, until you almost agreed.

Your job now is to start hearing those voices as voices, instead of as the weather. They will not stop overnight. They might not stop at all. But you can stop mistaking them for yours.

the self that gets edited.

Coercive control reshapes identity.

Sociologist Evan Stark coined the term coercive control to describe a pattern of abuse that is less about discrete violent incidents and more about a slow, total micromanagement of another person's life. What you wear. Who you see. What you eat. What you read. Who you text. How you laugh.

The damage is not only the rules. It is what happens to a self that learns to predict and pre-comply. Over time, the preferences you cannot safely have stop feeling like preferences. They feel like nothing. You forget you ever wanted them.

This is sometimes called self-silencing. It is associated in research with depression, autoimmune flare-ups, and chronic pain — the body's quiet protest against an identity that has been edited too much.

Identity-rebuilding is not vanity. It is the actual treatment for what coercive control did to you.

the things you stopped.

Music you used to love. Before you started checking who would hear it.

Foods you stopped eating. Because they were too much trouble to make for one. Or too messy. Or too you.

Clothes you stopped wearing. Because they got a comment. Because they made you visible.

Places you stopped going. Because they got monitored. Because they got mocked.

People you stopped seeing. Because the cost of seeing them got higher than the joy of it.

Opinions you stopped having out loud. Because the cost of disagreeing was higher than the cost of agreeing.

on style, more than aesthetic.

What you wear is data your body uses.

There is research on what psychologists call *enclothed cognition*: the clothes you put on shape your mood, your cognition, and even your sense of agency. White coats make people perform better on attention tasks. Formal clothing increases abstract thinking. Comfortable clothing increases self-reported authenticity.

For someone whose appearance was policed, getting dressed becomes a daily negotiation with a voice that is no longer in the room. Reclaiming style — the lipstick, the cut, the color, the silhouette — is not surface work. It is one of the most embodied ways to remember that you are not their project anymore.

Start tiny. One thing that is unmistakably yours. A ring. A perfume. A specific shade of nail polish. A pair of shoes you would not have been allowed. Notice what your body does when you put it on.

on finding your style again.

Style is not a magazine. Style is a record of what you have answered yes to.

If you have no idea where to start: spend a week noticing. What outfits do you see on other people that stop you for a beat. Not the ones you think are correct. The ones that make a small clean yes happen in your chest.

Save the images somewhere — a folder on your phone, a corkboard, a notebook. Don't curate. Just collect. Patterns will surface that you didn't know were yours.

Then, the smallest possible move. One piece. The exact shade of green. The shape of a sleeve. The boot. Wear it for a week. See if it still feels like yours, or if it was a yes for someone else.

You will be wrong sometimes. That is the work. Style is built out of small, corrected yeses, not one declaration.

things i want to try.

Old things, new things, ridiculous things, small things. Write more than feels reasonable.

on food again.

If you spent years cooking for someone else's tastes — or not cooking, because nothing you made was right — your relationship to food may have gone quiet. You eat what is easy. You eat standing up. You forget what you actually like.

Start by eating one thing on purpose. One meal a week that is for you, made or chosen with no one else's preferences in the room.

Try the food you used to want and were talked out of. Order the thing you would have been mocked for ordering. Buy the cheese that costs more than seems reasonable for one person. Eat the leftovers cold, in front of the open fridge, if that is the version of dinner your body wants.

Notice what your mouth wants when no one is watching. That is not greed. That is information.

on what you read, watch, listen to.

Your taste was not a discussion topic. Your taste was a target.

The book that got rolled eyes. The show that got laughed at. The artist whose music you stopped playing because of the comment. The genre you stopped admitting to.

Re-open one of them this week. Not to argue with anyone — they are not in the room. Just to see what your body does when it hears the first three notes, or reads the first paragraph, or watches the title card come up.

If the body says no, that is also fine. Tastes change. But it should be your no, not their leftover one.

my voice / their voice. _____

Write a sentence you say about yourself, then ask whose voice it is in. The more of these you do, the easier it gets to hear the difference.

THE SENTENCE	WHOSE VOICE

on your home, again.

Your space is part of your nervous system. The walls. The light. The chair. The bed. What you see when you open your eyes.

If you are in the same space where the harm happened — and you can't move yet, or don't want to — change one thing. The position of the bed. The lamp. The art. The smell. The first thing you see when you walk in.

If you are in a new space, take your time furnishing it. Don't fill the rooms because empty looks unfinished. Let yourself have a room with one chair in it. See what you actually want next, instead of what is missing.

Buy yourself flowers. Once a week if you can. Not for occasion. For Wednesday.

a small, true thing. _____

You are allowed to like what you like.

You do not need a reason.

The reason is that you like it.



Boundaries and scripts

boundaries are decisions about what you will do. they are not negotiations.



on what they actually are.

Boundaries are not rules you give other people to follow. They are decisions you make about your own next move.

A boundary is a sentence about what you will do, not a sentence about what they should stop doing. The clearer the next move is to you, the less you need them to agree to anything.

If raised voices in a conversation pull you out of yourself, the boundary is not asking them to lower their voice. It is knowing, before the conversation begins, that you will step outside the moment the volume rises, and that you do not need permission to leave.

Boundaries are not negotiations. They do not require the other person's understanding, agreement, or apology. They only require you to follow through on the move you already chose.

the three tiers.

Green. People who get the full version of you. They have earned access through years, or through a quick deep trust that proved itself. There will not be many. That is normal.

Yellow. People who get a cleaner version. The work face. The polite cousin. Real warmth, real limits. Most of the world lives here.

Red. People who get the gray rock. Short answers. No detail. No bait taken. You are not rude. You are not warm. You are weather.

scripts.

When you have spent years finding the perfect words to manage someone, leaving the perfect words behind is the hardest part. The new scripts are boring on purpose. Boring does not invite a follow-up.

Declining a conversation. "I'm not going to get into this." Period. Don't decorate it.

Declining contact. "I'm not available for that right now." "Right now" can mean forever. You don't have to say so.

When they push. "My answer is the same." Repeat it as needed. The repetition is the point.

When asked why. "I'd rather not get into it." If pushed: "That's still my answer."

When they get angry. Their anger is not your assignment. "I'm going to step away now." Then step away.

When apologized at. An apology is not a contract. "Thank you for saying that." Nothing else is owed.

why over-explaining backfires.

Your decision does not become more valid with explanation.

Every reason you give for a refusal is a door someone can try to walk through. "I can't come on Saturday because I'm tired" invites "but you could rest first" or "you're always tired." The reason becomes the negotiating table.

You do not owe elaboration for a refusal. Refusal is not something that must be defended. "I won't," or "I'm not available," or "that doesn't work for me," stands on its own. It is not rude. It is finished.

If the other person treats your answer as a draft to be edited, that is information about them, not a flaw in your sentence. You do not have to be understood to be allowed.

my non-negotiables.

The lines that don't move. Write them in your own words. Short. If a line needs an explanation, it isn't the line yet.

a sentence i can practice in the mirror.

One you will use this week. Boring on purpose.

VI

No contact as self-preservation

self-preservation is a complete sentence.



on the decision.

No contact is not punishment. It is not a tantrum. It is not waiting for them to learn the lesson so you can come back.

No contact is the decision that this relationship costs more than you can pay, and that paying it is no longer something you are willing to do.

It is also one of the loneliest decisions you will ever make.

the chemistry of trauma bonding.

Why leaving felt — and may still feel — impossible.

It is not the worst of them you miss. It is the unpredictability of the good moments. When kindness arrives at random — interrupting cruelty that also arrived at random — the body learns to wait. It learns to stay. It learns to read the air for any sign that the soft version is coming back.

That waiting is its own attachment. The cycle becomes more familiar than any one version of the person inside it. You can stop loving them and still feel a pull toward the rhythm — the small spike when the message finally comes, the relief when the room finally goes quiet, the brief, exhausted softness after a bad night.

What your body learned was not love. It was a pattern. A nervous-system dependency on emotional weather it could not control. Stepping out of that pattern is not the same as falling out of love. It is a longer, stranger, slower kind of unlearning.

Missing them is not a sign that leaving was wrong. It is a sign that a body that learned to live on whiplash is still adjusting to a life that no longer arrives in shocks. Be kind to a body that is still recalibrating. It can take months. It can take longer. It does pass.

three tools, not one.

There is a difference between no contact, low contact, and gray rock.

No contact: nothing. No calls, no messages, no checking their stories, no asking about them. They are dead to your inbox.

Low contact: the minimum required for shared responsibilities. Logistics only. Coparenting, estate, a shared business. Everything is in writing, brief, and never personal.

Gray rock: you are present but emotionally uninteresting. You give them nothing to react to. Useful when you cannot yet leave the room.

Pick the tool that fits the situation, not the one that fits your guilt.

the people who don't believe you.

Not everyone will believe you. Some of the people who don't believe you will be people you loved.

There are a few reasons for this. Sometimes the abuser got there first, with a version of the story that put them in the right. Sometimes the person who took their side has their own unhealed thing that makes your truth too costly to look at. Sometimes people just protect the image of the family more than the people in it.

Their disbelief is not evidence. It is information about them. It is allowed to break your heart. It is allowed to make you sob in the car. And it is still not evidence.

the loss ledger. _____

For the people you are losing alongside the one you left. Name them. Be specific. Grieve what was actually there, not what you wished was there.

WHO	WHAT I'M ACTUALLY LOSING

the tiered contact map. _____

Sort the people in your life by how reachable you are to them right now. This can change. Pencil, not pen, if you need it to.

NAME	TIER (NO / LOW / GRAY / SAFE)

the final message, if you send one.

You do not owe a closing argument. You do not owe a goodbye message. You do not owe an explanation. Most final messages are written for the writer, not the reader.

If you do send one, keep it short. "I'm not going to be in contact with you. Please don't reach out." One sentence. No reasons. Reasons are something they will argue with. The decision is not a negotiation.

the digital no-contact protocol.

Slow, boring, total.

Do as many as apply. Tick them as you go.

- ☐ Block on phone (calls, texts, both numbers if they have a backup)
- ☐ Block on every social platform — including the ones you don't use
- ☐ Mute mutual friends' tagged photos and stories if needed
- ☐ Remove from emergency contacts on your phone
- ☐ Audit shared logins (streaming, cloud, password managers)
- ☐ Take yourself off shared family calendars and location sharing
- ☐ Pre-write a script for mutuals: "I'm not discussing it." Period.
- ☐ Decide in advance what you do if you see them in public

on grieving a living person.

You are grieving someone who is still alive. That is its own kind of grief, and very few rituals know what to do with it.

You are also grieving the version of them you needed them to be. That version was real to you. Its loss is real, too.

Sometimes you will miss them. Not the worst of them — the best of them. The good Tuesdays. The shared joke. The way they laughed at your bit. Missing the good does not undo the bad. Both were true. Both are over.

if you slip. _____

If you reach out. If you answer the call. If you check their page. If you sleep with them once more after you said never again.

Close the door again. The door will close. It has closed before. You are not weak. You are someone who loved a person who hurt you. That is the actual situation. Be kind to the person trying to leave it.

Slipping is not a verdict on the decision. It is the same pattern described two pages ago, doing exactly what patterns do. Note it. Notice what hooked you. Close the door. Start again the next morning.

who am i protecting by staying reachable to them?

Write the names. Write the cost. Decide what to do with the answer.

VII

Treat yo self

pleasure is not the reward. pleasure is the medicine.



on small, often, on purpose.

Pleasure is not the reward at the end. Pleasure is the medicine.

When a body has spent years braced for impact, the body forgets that it is allowed to want anything for its own sake. Every want gets audited. Every yes gets earned. Every joy gets a tax.

Untraining that is small, daily, on purpose. A cup of something warm with no one watching. A song played twice in a row because you liked it that much. A small extravagance that solves nothing and makes the day feel like yours.

This is not frivolous. This is the work.

the neuroscience of small pleasure.

Joy is a chemical antidote.

Pleasure releases dopamine (anticipation and motivation), serotonin (mood stability), oxytocin (bonding and warmth), and endorphins (pain relief). These are the same systems that get suppressed by chronic stress.

Crucially, the brain does not distinguish between big pleasure and small pleasure in terms of the chemical response. A single piece of dark chocolate, eaten slowly, produces a measurable dopamine release. A favorite song produces serotonin. A hand on your own chest releases oxytocin.

This is why small, daily pleasure is more powerful than rare, big pleasure for nervous-system repair. The system needs frequency, not size. One small joy a day, every day, rebuilds the chemistry faster than one big vacation a year.

Allow yourself the small thing. The small thing is the dose.

the reclamation list.

Below: thirty small pleasures you used to have, or never let yourself have, that are yours again. Write the ones that fit. Cross out the ones that don't. Add your own.

the song played loud. the meal eaten slowly. the second cup of coffee. the bath that takes too long. the candle lit for no occasion. the book read in bed at noon. the long walk with no podcast. the new flowers, weekly. the napkins, even when it's just you. the perfume put on for the grocery store. the small tattoo, the new haircut, the lipstick you used to be told was too much. the dance in the kitchen. the cry to the movie. the laugh in the car. the playlist made for one. the room rearranged because you felt like it. the meal cooked just for the smell of it. the silk thing. the soft thing. the loud thing. the bright thing. the trip alone. the meal alone. the saturday morning that belongs to no one. the sentence said out loud, only for you. the no, given without an apology. the yes, given without a reason. the small purchase, just because. the long sleep. the slow morning. the body, returned to itself.

the sensory menu.

When the body asks for something and you don't know what — pick by sense.

Taste. Something cold and sharp. Something warm and slow. The first bite of a fruit in season. A drink that takes ten minutes to finish.

Touch. A heavy blanket. A bare foot on grass. A long shower. A hand on your own chest. Lotion put on like you mean it.

Sound. A song you loved at sixteen. Rain on a window. The voice of a friend on speakerphone. A room with no sound at all.

Sight. A candle in a dark room. A window with a tree in it. A page in a book whose font you love. A single fresh flower on the table.

Smell. Coffee in the morning. Bread baking. The neck of someone you love. Clean laundry. A perfume that is just yours.

the just-because log.

One unearned good thing you gave yourself today. No justification allowed. If you wrote a reason, cross it out.

the spite joy list. _____

Spite joy is a real and underrated medicine. Make a list of the things they mocked, forbade, or would hate that you can now have, wear, do, watch, listen to, eat, befriend.

This is not about them. They will never know. The point is the small, private pleasure of being a person they no longer get to edit.

spite joys. _____

Things they mocked, forbade, or would hate that are now yours. Petty is healing.

permission slips. _____

I am allowed to enjoy this without earning it.

I do not owe anyone an explanation for what makes me happy.

Pleasure is not a debt I am going to pay for.

My body is not the receipt for anyone else's comfort.

Small joys count. Quiet joys count. Petty joys count.

I am the only one keeping score, and I quit.

what would i do today if no one was keeping score?

Write the answer. Then go do one thing on the list, however small.

VIII

The long view

boring is the goal. done is the goal. perfect is not on the list.



on slow infrastructure.

Long-form safety is not a panic plan. It is the slow, boring infrastructure that means future-you doesn't have to think about any of this in the worst moment.

Boring is the goal. Done is the goal. Perfect is not on the list.

on the legal landscape.

What protection orders actually do, and don't.

A civil protection order (also called a restraining order, order of protection, or peace order, depending on your state) is a court order telling someone not to contact, approach, or harm you. Violating one is a separate crime, which means police can act on it without re-litigating the underlying abuse.

Limits to know: a protection order is a piece of paper, not a force field. It does not guarantee physical safety. Its real power is procedural — it puts a paper trail in place, it lowers the threshold for police involvement, and in many jurisdictions it can include orders about housing, finances, and pets.

Cost should not be a barrier. Almost every U.S. state has free legal aid for domestic violence survivors. WomensLaw.org, the National Domestic Violence Hotline (1-800-799-7233), and your local DV shelter can all connect you with free representation.

Document everything before you file. Dates, times, witnesses, screenshots, photos. The boring archive becomes evidence.

legal.

What to gather and where to keep it.

- ☐ Originals or copies of: ID, passport, birth certificate, marriage/divorce, immigration papers
- ☐ Court documents, restraining orders, police reports — kept somewhere they cannot reach
- ☐ A consultation with a family / DV attorney, even briefly, even free
- ☐ A written timeline of incidents — boring, dated, factual
- ☐ Photos of injuries, screenshots of messages, voicemails — backed up off-device

on financial recovery.

Financial abuse is the most common form of control.

Roughly 99 percent of domestic violence cases involve some form of financial abuse: controlling access to money, sabotaging employment, running up debt in the victim's name, or hiding marital assets.

Concrete first steps: a credit report from each of the three bureaus (free at annualcreditreport.com) tells you what is in your name. An account at a different bank — physically different, not a different branch — gives you a place to send a paycheck or a transfer that no one else can see. Many DV agencies run matched-savings programs that double whatever you put in.

If your credit is wrecked, it is rebuildable. A secured credit card (you deposit a few hundred dollars, that becomes your limit) used for one recurring small charge and paid off monthly will measurably raise your score within a year. Boring, slow, real.

financial. _____

Boring is the goal.

- ☐ An account in only your name, at a different bank
- ☐ A small recurring transfer to it — even \$20
- ☐ Credit in your own name, slowly built
- ☐ Knowing the passwords to your own money
- ☐ Cash you can access without explanation
- ☐ A copy of tax returns and pay stubs you can find without asking
- ☐ A free credit report from each of the three bureaus, once a year

digital.

Locks on the things that talk.

- ☐ Your own email on a device they have not touched
- ☐ Two-factor on every account, set to your number only
- ☐ Audit of family-share plans, cloud storage, location sharing
- ☐ Strong, new passwords stored in a manager
- ☐ Old shared accounts: removed, transferred, or closed
- ☐ Photo backups in a place that is only yours
- ☐ Check your phone for stalkerware (Settings → Privacy → Apps with permissions; reset if unsure)

physical.

A door you can walk out of, tonight if you needed to.

- ☐ A spare key with someone outside the situation
- ☐ A go-bag — small, packed, accessible: ID, meds, charger, cash, change of clothes, comfort item
- ☐ A safe place you can go any night of the week without warning
- ☐ Numbers memorized, not just stored in the phone
- ☐ A code word with one trusted person

ten percent.

If all of this feels like too much: choose one thing. The smallest, most boring one. Do it this week.

Then choose one more. The goal is not to be ten times safer by Friday. The goal is to be ten percent safer than you were Monday. Ten percent, every week, becomes a different life.

IX

The long way back

a homecoming. slower. quieter. with no audience at the door.



on the days that surprise you.

You will not arrive. There is not a day you are done.

There will be a day, though — and then more days, and more — when you notice you have not flinched in a while. When a knock at the door is just a knock. When a phone ringing is just a phone. When a man's voice in a parking lot is just a man's voice in a parking lot.

Those days will surprise you. They will sneak in. You will not earn them through correct work. They will arrive, the way weather arrives, because the season has changed.

not a comeback.

What you are doing is not a comeback. It is a homecoming. Slower.
Quieter. With no audience at the door.

You are not going back to who you were before. That person did not yet know what you know. You are going forward to someone who has carried this, and is no longer being carried by it. That person is more interesting than the one before. That person is yours.

on meeting people again.

Your social life may have been pruned to almost nothing. Some of the cuts were theirs. Some were yours. Either way, the room is sparse now, and the temptation is to fill it fast.

Don't. The reflex to rush — to find a new circle, a new partner, a new family — is the same nervous system that learned to fix things fast so they would stop being scary. Slow is the medicine.

Start with low-stakes recurring contact, not high-stakes intimacy. A weekly class. A volunteer shift. A regular coffee shop where the barista learns your order. The same dog park at the same hour. Bodies become familiar to other bodies through repetition, not depth. Depth follows.

One real friendship in a year is a successful year. Two is a wealthy one.

on friendship, in particular.

Adult friendship is built on three ingredients, in roughly this order: proximity (you see them often), shared activity (you do something together), and vulnerability (you tell them something true). Most people fail at adult friendship because they try to skip from one to three.

Pick the proximity first. Where will you be regularly anyway? A choir. A yoga class. A book club. A standing brunch with anyone who'll come. The relationship gets built in the boring middle, not in the deep conversation you imagine.

Be the one who reaches out twice in a row before deciding it's not mutual. Be the one who says "this Thursday?" instead of "we should hang out sometime." The specific invitation is the work.

loneliness is a vital sign.

Your body treats isolation as a wound.

Chronic loneliness raises cortisol, increases systemic inflammation, and is associated with a mortality risk comparable to smoking fifteen cigarettes a day. The brain interprets prolonged social isolation as a survival threat — because, evolutionarily, it was one.

The good news in the same research: it does not take a lot to move the needle. Brief positive social contact — a real exchange with a barista, a five-minute call with a friend, a wave to a neighbor — measurably reduces the loneliness signal in the body.

This is one reason the smallest social commitments matter. Showing up to a weekly anything beats waiting for a single deep friendship to materialize.

on dating, if and when.

There is no correct timeline. Some people are ready at six months. Some at three years. Some never want to again, and that is a complete and honorable life.

If and when you do: notice what your body does in the first ten minutes, not what your story about them is in the first three weeks. The body knows things the conversation hides.

Slow is the most romantic word. Anyone who pushes past your slow is someone whose default is push. Note it. It will not change later.

A short list of green flags worth more than most: they ask what you want and listen to the answer. They are at ease with their own boredom. They have friends they have kept for a long time. They are kind to people who can't do anything for them. They can apologize without making it about themselves. They get less interesting under stress, not more dramatic.

A short list of red flags worth taking seriously: rushed pace, intensity that flatters but doesn't ask, casual disrespect of an ex (without context), poor relationship with their own anger, jealousy framed as love, isolation framed as preference, a story where everyone in their past is the problem.

on rebuilding trust in the body.

Why intimacy can re-introduce panic.

If your body learned that closeness was where harm came from, closeness will register as threat — even when the closeness is welcome, even when you chose it. Heart racing, dissociation, sudden numbness, the urge to flee, crying that comes from nowhere.

This is not a moral failing or a sign that the new person is wrong for you. It is the body firing on old data. The work is to make new data.

Slow physical contact, in small doses, with eyes open, with permission to stop at any moment, lets the body update its files. A hand held for a minute. A hug that ends when you want it to end. Sex that is allowed to stop midway with no debrief required.

If trauma keeps interrupting intimacy, a somatic or trauma-trained therapist is the most useful person to find. This is not a shortcoming. This is one of the most common parts of recovery.

on your body, again.

Coming back to your body after harm is not a yoga class. It is hundreds of tiny acts of saying yes when you mean yes and no when you mean no, and feeling the body believe you.

Move it in ways that are not punishment. Walking. Swimming. Dancing alone. Lifting things. The point is not aesthetic. The point is the body learning that you are on its side.

Touch it kindly, on purpose, daily. Lotion after a shower with attention. A hand on your own heart in the morning. A long stretch before bed. The body has been treated like a problem to manage. It is your turn to treat it like an inhabitant.

Get the bloodwork done if you can — chronic stress depletes specific things and a normal physical can reveal what to rebuild. Get the dental work you put off. Get the eye exam. The body has been waiting.

on the people who saw it.

Some people stayed. The friend who took the late-night calls. The cousin who let you sleep on the couch the first week. The coworker who didn't ask but somehow always knew when to bring soup.

Thank them. Out loud. Now. Not when you have figured everything out. Now.

And let the relationship change. The shape of friendship you needed during the worst of it may not be the shape you need now. That's not betrayal. That's the friendship doing exactly what it was built for, and then being free to become something else.

on telling the story.

There will be a moment, eventually, when you want to tell the story. To a partner. To a friend. To a therapist. To a page.

You do not owe it to anyone. Not your new partner. Not your new friends. Not the people who think they earned access by being kind. The story is yours. The telling is a gift, not a tax.

When you do tell it: notice if you are telling it for them or for you. Tell it for you. The shape that helps you is not always the shape that explains the most. It is the shape that lets your body put it down for a minute.

the question. _____

What do I want the next year to look like? Not the answer. Just the question, in your own handwriting. Come back to it whenever you want. Change the year.

a final note.

There is no graduation. There is no certificate. There is no one who will hand you a piece of paper that says: it is over, you may now be a normal person again.

There is, instead, a Tuesday afternoon where you realize you have not thought about it all day. A Saturday morning where the first thing you notice is the light on the wall. A phone call where you laugh, and the laugh is one you have not heard out of yourself in years.

Those are the receipts. Not the certificate. The Tuesday. The light. The laugh.

You took the long way. It is still your way. And the body you came home to was always yours.

open pages.

The rest is yours. No prompts. Write nothing. Write everything. Date the entries or don't.

*You took the long way.
It is still your way.*

*And the body you came home to
was always yours.*



INNER HOUR